Requirements Gathering Process Guide

Requirements gathering defines the goals, scope, and specific needs of a project before building begins. Following a structured framework minimizes scope creep, aligns stakeholders, and ensures project delivery matches expectations.

1. Identify Stakeholders

- Find everyone impacted by or invested in the project, including internal teams (executives, managers, developers) and external parties (customers, vendors).
- Map stakeholders by influence and interest to spot potential alignment conflicts early.

2. Plan the Approach

- Define project objectives, high-level scope, timelines, and required resources.
- Choose elicitation techniques tailored to the audience, such as one-on-one interviews, collaborative workshops, user surveys, or interface shadowing.

3. Conduct Elicitation

- Meet with stakeholders to extract what they need the ultimate product or service to accomplish.
- Focus heavily on fundamental business needs and underlying problems rather than specific software tools or premature design details.

4. Document Observations and Findings

- Record all answers, requests, comments, and constraints in a centralized document or system tracker.
- Categorize items clearly into functional requirements (what it must do), non-functional requirements (how it must perform), and absolute project constraints.

5. Analyze and Prioritize

- Evaluate collected requirements for technical feasibility, business value, and technical dependencies.
- Apply prioritization frameworks like **MoSCoW** (Must have, Should have, Could have, Won't have) or the Kano model to rank capabilities.

6. Verify and Validate

- Review the structured list directly with stakeholders through walkthroughs, wireframes, or rough prototypes to ensure absolute accuracy and completeness.
- Secure a formal, recorded sign-off from primary owners before active engineering or development begins.

7. Manage Changes

- Establish a baseline configuration along with a robust traceability matrix to follow requirements throughout implementation.
- Implement a formal change-control process to manage evolving scopes, mid-project discoveries, or missed items gracefully.